EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

If It Was Decreed, Am I Still to Blame?

Given Monday 2 December 2024 · Emunot VeDeot, Essay 4:5

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon

Essay/Chapters: Essay 4 (Free Will), Chapter 5, questions 3 to 7, and the opening of Chapter 6

Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 2 December 2024, on Zoom

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap: Where We Are in the Fourth Essay

The fourth essay of Emunot VeDeot is Rav Saadia Gaon's treatment of human free will. The Rabbi reviewed the ground covered so far:

- **Chapters 1 and 2:** Saadia builds his picture of the world with **man at the centre**, and tries to prove that humans are the purpose of the creation of the universe. As the class saw at the time, that argument "wasn't so straightforward."
- **Chapter 3:** Saadia's own view of free will. A human has **complete and absolute free will**. Free will comes **before the action**, not at the same moment as it, and it also covers **abstaining** from something.
- **Chapter 4:** Saadia's four kinds of proof that humans have free will: from the **senses**, from **logic**, from **Scripture**, and from **the Talmud and tradition**. That chapter also took up the age-old question of how human free will fits with Hashem's full knowledge.
- **Chapter 5 (begun last week):** seven questions about free will. Two were done last week:
- Why command the righteous, if Hashem knows they will do the right thing anyway? Because humans need to know what the right thing is.
- Why send prophets and messengers to the wicked, if Hashem knows they will sin? Saadia gave six or seven answers, but the main one is that **they will have no excuse** to say they did not know.

"We'll see Saadia really holds with this strongly," the Rabbi said of absolute free will. "We'll see this in a few examples this evening."

Questions 3 and 4: The Decreed Death and the Decreed Loss

Saadia's text

The third question: suppose it has been decreed that a person is going to die, whether as a punishment or as some kind of trial. Someone else then decides, with his own free will, to kill him. To whom do we attribute the action?

Saadia answers:

- **The fact that the victim died** was the decree of God.
- **The fact that he was killed** was the work of the killer, and **he will be held accountable** for it. "He would have died naturally had it not been for the perpetrator."

The fourth question is the same case with money. If it was decreed that a person will lose money, and someone steals it from him, then the loss was the decree of God, but the fact that it happened **through theft** was the thief's action, and he will be held accountable. Had it not been stolen, it would have been lost in some other way, perhaps through a fine.

Saadia supports this with the answer that **Shemaya and his brother** gave to the king of Edom who was about to execute them: we have been decreed to die whether you kill us or not, perhaps by a natural death, but you will still be held accountable for deciding to kill us.

The Rabbi's question to the class

Before explaining the two ways of reading this, the Rabbi put a question to the class:

"If it's been decided and decreed upon a person on Rosh Hashanah, you will be poor... I see this person, he's a friend of mine, I have huge compassion for him, and I decide I'm going to completely look after him. Is it possible for me, a third party, to come in and change the decree of HaKadosh Baruch Hu?"

He made clear that this is not about teshuvah. Of course **תשובה ותפילה וצדקה מעבירין את רוע הגזרה**: repentance, prayer and charity remove the evil of the decree. The question is about someone who has not changed at all: "I'm the same person I was six months ago when this decree was passed on me. Can someone *else* now come and change that?"

- **One participant** suggested that the decree itself might be open-ended. It is decreed that a person will be poor, but part of the decree may be that the poverty can be alleviated by others, just as some illnesses are decreed with the possibility of healing and some without. The Rabbi called this "a middle view between the two views" and said it could be "the beginning of trying to bridge" the two readings.
- **Flora** felt that for Saadia this would not work, since whatever happens, pleasant or harsh, was the decree. She found the deterministic picture difficult, and raised **Chizkiyahu**, who was told he would die and was given another fifteen years.

Reading 1: everything was going to happen anyway

The first and simpler reading of Saadia is that **everything that happens to a person has already been determined**, and all the merit or punishment we receive is for being **the one who brings it about**.

On this reading, if I bring a poor man off the street and look after him, it was always decreed on Rosh Hashanah that by a certain date he would end up in a home with plenty of food. I am rewarded for choosing to be the one who did it. If I kill someone at 6:11 on the second of December, it was already decreed that he would die at 6:11 on the second of December. I am punished because I was the conduit, and because he could have died peacefully at home rather than by a knife.

The consequence: "our free will doesn't really have the effect to change anything in the world," because everything is going to happen for the good or for the bad. "Really we are just robots doing things. Yes, we're choosing to do them, that's true. But really our choices are quite not really meaningful, because they would have happened anyway."

Rabbeinu Bachya, Chovot HaLevavot, says something similar, and even more strongly. He teaches that no one can hurt a person without Hashem's agreement. If you depend on many masters, you must keep pleasing all of them. If there is only one Master who can do good or bad to you, you will trust only in Him. Once a person recognises that **nothing can happen to him without Hashem's will**, he stops worrying and stops hoping that people will be good to him or fearing they will be bad to him.

Reading 2: the Or HaChaim and the brothers of Yosef

The Rabbi then brought what he called "a fascinating" reading from the **Or HaChaim**, Rabbi Chaim ben Attar of Morocco (late 1600s to 1700s), on the story of Yosef and his brothers, which was about to be read in shul in a couple of weeks.

The brothers say: let us kill him, **ונראה מה יהיו חלמתיו**, "and we will see what becomes of his dreams." Reuven says, let us not take his life; throw him into the pit instead. The simple reading is that Reuven simply did not want them to do it with their own hands. The Or HaChaim reads it as a **theological debate about free will**:

1. **The brothers' reasoning.** Everything happens by the will of Hashem. If Yosef's dreams are true, we must respect him. If they are false, he is a false dreamer, a kind of false prophet, and deserves death. So here is a simple litmus test: try to kill him. If we succeed, his dreams were never true, because it could only happen if Hashem willed it. If we fail, his dreams are true.
2. **Reuven's answer.** You have misunderstood. **Even if it has been decreed that a person will live, a human being, through his free will, has the ability to go against it.** Yosef might be meant to live and his dreams might be true, and you could still kill him. Your killing him would prove nothing.
3. **Reuven's alternative test.** Put him in the pit. The snakes and scorpions there do not mean certain death; the Rishonim write that he could have survived. **A human has free will and can kill someone decreed to live, but an animal, a snake or a scorpion will only attack a person if it has been decreed upon him.** So if he survives the pit, his dreams are true; if the creatures kill him, it was decreed.

That is the meaning of **ויצלהו מידם**, "he saved him from their hands." Reuven saved the brothers from their mistaken view of free will. "And Reuven wins the day."

The Rabbi added that **the Zohar** on that parasha says essentially the same, though the Or HaChaim does not cite it: a human can do anything. If someone is decreed to be poor, I have the ability as a human to improve the world and take him off the streets, "and I'll be going against Hashem as well, and that's fine. Hashem has given us free will to be able to use it for the good and for the bad."

What is at stake

	Reading 1 (simple reading of Saadia; Chovot HaLevavot)	Reading 2 (Or HaChaim; Zohar)
Can my choice change what happens to another person?	No. It would have happened anyway	Yes. A human can override what was decreed
What am I rewarded or punished for?	Being the conduit, and the harsh or kind *way* it happened	The outcome itself
How meaningful are our choices?	Limited	"Far more meaningful"
What must I worry about?	Only my standing with Hashem	Also other people's free will

The second reading has a cost: "We can't just hope and pray that Hashem looks after us. We also have to hope and pray that we're not affected by other people's free will." When we pray on Rosh Hashanah for life, we pray to live naturally, but we still have to take precautions against other people. Even so, Rabbi Tatz argues that there is a concept of extra shielding: someone with real merit can sometimes be protected from these things.

Rabbi Tatz's reading of Saadia

Rabbi Akiva Tatz, "well known in London," has a book called *Freedom, Will and Destiny*, which the Rabbi "highly recommended," especially its chapter in the middle on whether one person can affect another. Rabbi Tatz goes through all the views and notes that Saadia is the first to seem to say that we only do what was going to happen anyway. But he wants to read Saadia **like the Or HaChaim**: Saadia is only addressing the very specific case in which a death was already decreed, and asking how the action is attributed.

The Rabbi was not convinced. A decree of death is for a specific date and time. If Saadia held like the Or HaChaim, his question would only arise in the "extremely remote" case where I happen to decide to kill someone at exactly the moment he was decreed to die naturally. "Why would Saadia be asking such a remote and theoretical question?" So the Rabbi believes the simple reading is correct: Saadia holds that when a person is killed, it was decreed that he die at that time, and the killer is punished for his not dying naturally.

"I personally prefer the second view, because it means life becomes much more meaningful. But I think we have to admit the simple reading of Saadia makes our choices in life quite meaningless, in that we are just doing what would have happened in the world anyway... more accented, for the good and for the bad."

A question from the class

If I was only the instrument of what God wanted, why should I be punished?

The Rabbi: according to Saadia, you chose to be the instrument. Had you chosen good, the person would have died in his bed, or slipped and died. He died through your killing him, and you are held accountable for that. When the participant pressed that the decree might have been "to be killed," the Rabbi answered that even then it could have been by anyone, even by a bear. The fact that this particular human chose to do it is what he is responsible for.

"Where was man?"

The Rabbi closed this section with **Rabbi Lord Jonathan Sacks**, zichrono livracha. When asked where God was during the Holocaust, Rabbi Sacks would answer: **where was man during the Holocaust?** That answer, the Rabbi said, "is only intelligible according to the second reading." It may well be that God decreed for all those people to live, and humans chose evil. It is a fundamental principle, as we learned in the Rambam, that humans have free will and Hashem does not intervene with it. On the simple reading of Saadia, "and definitely according to Rabbeinu Bachya," Rabbi Sacks' answer has no ground to stand on. On the second reading it is a beautiful answer: the Jews were meant to live, and the Nazis went against the decree of HaKadosh Baruch Hu and are culpable for it.

Question 5: David, Batsheva and Avshalom

After David's sin with Batsheva ("we don't need to go into the details of what exactly the sin was; there's a whole discussion on that"), the prophet Natan told him: **הנני מקים עליך רעה מביתך**, "I will raise up evil against you from your own house." Someone from his household would take his wives: "you did it in secret, and I will do this before all Israel." This was **Avshalom**, who publicly took David's ten concubines.

So the question: if this was decreed as David's punishment, **what happened to Avshalom's free will?**

Saadia's answer

Hashem, through Natan, was telling David **what Avshalom was going to choose**. Avshalom had complete free will to do it or not; Hashem simply knew he would. This follows Saadia's answer in chapter 4 to the question of free will and divine knowledge: Hashem knows the end that the human will choose.

But then, if Avshalom was going to do it anyway, how is this a punishment for David? Saadia adds: the punishment was **to pain David's heart** with the knowledge. Living with the knowledge that your own child is going to behave this way, until it happens, "is a terrible punishment."

The Rabbi pointed out that, again, on Saadia's view **it would have happened anyway**, regardless of what David did with Batsheva.

The Radak's in-between view

The **Radak**, Rabbi David Kimchi, on this verse, asks the same question and answers differently. Hashem knew Avshalom was a lustful person who was going to sin with some woman in any case. Had David not sinned, Hashem would have made sure it was **not** with David's wives, which is far worse. Because of David's sin, Avshalom's choice was directed to David's household. The decree was that something bad would come from his house; Avshalom chose to sin; the decree determined *with whom*. "It's a kind of in-between." The Radak quotes Saadia at the end and does not seem to disagree with him; it is another interpretation.

Question 6: "Ashur, the Rod of My Anger"

The prophets describe the wicked kings who devastated Israel as **the instruments of God**: **הוי אשור שבט אפי**, "Woe, Ashur, the rod of My anger," and of the king of Babylon, **ונתתי את חרבי בידו**, "I

will put My sword in his hand." It sounds as if Hashem is telling them to do these terrible things.

Saadia's answer has two parts:

1. **Hashem gives them the ability**, by not holding them back.
2. **Hashem gives them the courage.**

"I'm not telling you to do it, but I'm giving you the possibility and the potential to be able to do it. And in that sense, if you go and do it, you are My staff." It is entirely their choice, and Hashem knows they will do it. That is why the same prophet says that Hashem will punish the arrogance of the king of Ashur. In that sense **Sancheriv and Nevuchadnezzar** are Hashem's staff and stick.

Question 7: Does Hashem Ever Make the Righteous Lie?

If everything that happens is Hashem's decree, and righteous people sometimes need to lie for good reasons, as we were reading in the recent parashiyot about Avraham and Yitzchak, then it seems Hashem is causing the righteous to lie.

Saadia's answer

1. **You never really have to lie.** "There's always a way out." People who lie, and then say "I had no choice," are blaming God.
2. **Use language that can be understood more than one way.** Even when you have licence to say something untrue, for example when your life or your wife is in danger, you can speak metaphorically. If the other person takes you literally and misunderstands, "that's his problem, not yours."

Avraham and Sarah. Avraham said **אחותי היא**, "she is my sister." He meant my relative: she was his niece, the daughter of his brother Haran. The Torah uses "brother" in this wider sense elsewhere: Avraham says to Lot, his nephew, **כי אנשים אחים אנחנו**, "for we are brothers." The people of the place took it literally and wanted to sin with her, and the sin was theirs. Saadia adds that it is common courtesy to ask a visitor about his work and his needs, not to ask how a woman travelling with him is related to him; Avraham sensed that something was wrong in that place.

Yaakov and Yitzchak. The Rabbi added an example "which springs to mind" from the previous week's parasha. Yaakov said **אנכי עשו בכרך**. Rashi reads it as two statements: "I am" the one bringing you food, and "Esav is your firstborn." What looks like a lie is not.

Saadia ends the chapter by saying he has given seven questions and seven answers. When you meet similar questions, "you have to use your common sense." He cannot address every single problem.

The Rabbi's difficulty, and a simpler answer

"I don't fully understand this." The Talmud says in many places, in many contexts, that a person is allowed to say something untrue: for humility, for modesty, to avoid causing harm to others, for the sake of peace, and when life is in danger. "To say that really a person never has to lie, I think is quite difficult."

The Rabbi preferred a much simpler answer, the one given by **Rav Dessler**, which he said he was used to: **truth and falsehood are not about factual accuracy, but about what is right**. In the Holocaust, a non-Jew is hiding a Jew in his house and a Nazi asks whether there is a Jew inside. He answers no. Saadia would have him craft an ambiguous sentence, but "you'll be caught out."

The simple point is that here you have licence to lie; "it's the mitzvah to lie here, actually. That's actually emet." *Emet* and *sheker* ask whether this is the right thing, whether it is *nachon*. In that sense there is no question at all, because saying the right thing is saying the truth, and it is no sin.

Summary of Chapter 5

Question	Saadia's answer
1. Why command the righteous?	Humans need to know what is right
2. Why send prophets to the wicked?	So they have no excuse
3 and 4. A decreed death or loss carried out by someone else	The outcome was God's decree; the harsh way it happened is the perpetrator's, and he is accountable
5. Avshalom and David's wives	Hashem foretold what Avshalom would freely choose; David's punishment was knowing in advance
6. Ashur and Babylon as God's rod and sword	Hashem gave them the ability and courage, but the choice was theirs
7. Does Hashem make the righteous lie?	One can always avoid an outright lie, using language open to interpretation

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Chapter 6: Verses That Seem to Deny Free Will

The class had been extended to finish the essay, since there would be no shiur the following week and probably not the week after. The Rabbi began the sixth and final chapter.

Saadia: "I will complete my essay by bringing the places in Tanach where there are doubts about free will." Almost all of them, he says, come from **not recognising that language is fluid**. The Rabbi recalled the earlier discussion of **anthropomorphisms** in the Torah (Essay 2), where Saadia was the first, at least the first recorded, to be unequivocal that Hashem has no body and that all the bodily descriptions are metaphors. There he wrote a small essay on how language is used: if we always take language strictly, our ability to express ourselves is very limited, so language must be allowed to stretch. The same applies here. Saadia gives **eight categories** of verses, with at least one example of each, and any other verse can be put under one of them.

Category 1: a warning is not a compulsion

Some verses are **Hashem warning us, not forcing us**. The example is from Parashat Vayera. Avraham and Sarah come to Gerar, Avimelech takes Sarah, and Hashem comes to him at night. Avimelech protests that he did not know she was a married woman. Hashem says: **ואחשך גם אנכי אותך מחטוא לי**, "I also withheld you from sinning against Me."

Saadia: people think Hashem physically stopped him. Wrong. It means **I commanded you not to**. Compare the Torah's language elsewhere:

- A man who divorced his wife, after she married someone else: **לא יוכל בעלה הראשון... לשוב לקחתה**, "her first husband *cannot* take her back." Of course he physically can. It means he is commanded not to.
  outside the chosen place: "you *cannot* sacrifice the Pesach." Of course I **לא תוכל לזבוח את הפסח** can take my lamb and slaughter it outside Jerusalem. It means I have been commanded not to.

So "I withheld you" means I warned you and commanded you not to sin with a married woman.

The Rabbi offered "special bonus marks" for another example Saadia does not bring, and gave one from Sefer Devarim: a man with two wives, one more loved than the other, whose firstborn is from the less loved wife. **לא יוכל לבכר את בן האהובה**, "he *cannot* give the firstborn's double portion to the son of the beloved." Of course he can. He is "not able" in relation to Hashem's will, because he has been commanded not to.

A very original reading

"This is, I have to tell you, a very original reading. What he says about the language is true, but his reading of the story of Avimelech and Sarah is very original." The Rishonim did not read it this way:

Commentator	"I withheld you from sinning" means
Rashi	Hashem took away his **physical strength**
Radak	Hashem took away his **desire** to sin
Saadia	Hashem **commanded** him; Avimelech could have sinned and chose not to

The simple reading, the Rabbi said, is that Hashem does sometimes intervene and suspend free will in unique circumstances: "how is Hashem going to allow Avraham's wife Sarah to be defiled?" Hashem momentarily paused Avimelech's free will. "Saadia doesn't like that, because for Saadia free will is comprehensive." Theoretically, Avimelech could have done it; he did not, because he recognised how terrible the sin was. "Saadia has a few very novel approaches to the pesukim in Tanach, which we're very surprised when we see them."

Coming Up

Rather than rush through the rest of the chapter, the Rabbi asked the class and decided "it's better we do things properly." The remaining seven categories of Chapter 6, with more of Saadia's novel readings of Tanach on free will, will be done in two or three weeks, after which the class begins Essay 5. There will be no shiur next week; the group will be told about the week after. "Chodesh tov, everyone."

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